

VOICE OF HEALTHCARE AND HORIBA INDIA HOSTS HIGH-IMPACT ROUNDTABLE ON DIAGNOSTIC STEWARDSHIP AND ANTIBIOTIC MISUSE

"The Role of Diagnostics in Curbing the Irrational Use of Antibiotics at the Point of Care" was the focal theme of a significant roundtable hosted by **Voice of Healthcare (VOH)** in collaboration with **HORIBA India,** on **April 11, 2025,** at **Shangri-La Eros, New Delhi.** With **antimicrobial resistance (AMR)** rapidly emerging as one of the world's most urgent public health crises — second only to climate change — the roundtable provided an essential platform to spotlight the role of diagnostic stewardship in combating this growing challenge.

India continues to bear one of the world's highest AMR burdens, driven by irrational antibiotic use, over-the-counter availability, and empirical, non-evidence-based prescribing patterns, particularly in ICUs, emergency care, and primary healthcare. Despite considerable advances in medical technology, timely, reliable, and affordable diagnostic interventions remain inconsistent, often leading to the unnecessary use of antibiotics. This roundtable united India's leading clinicians, policymakers, microbiologists, diagnostics experts, and public health specialists to collaboratively explore solutions that can strengthen diagnostic pathways and improve antibiotic stewardship across healthcare settings.

The event opened with a powerful keynote address by **Dr. Naveen Nishchal,** Founder Chairman, Voice of Healthcare, who highlighted real-world challenges and international perceptions around AMR in India. He shared a personal anecdote reflecting how hospital-acquired infections and AMR are viewed globally, underscoring the urgent need for India to act. **"AMR today stands as the second biggest global health threat after climate change. Diagnostics and point-of-care testing have the power to transform how we manage this issue — and every stakeholder needed to make this change is present in this room today. Together, we must not only discuss but act, strategize, and implement,"** Dr. Nishchal emphasized while warmly welcoming the gathering.

Dr. Rajeev Gautam, Sr. Corporate Officer, HORIBA Ltd. Japan and President, HORIBA India, followed with a keynote from an industry leader's perspective. He shared how HORIBA — traditionally known for its global leadership in medical diagnostics, biolife sciences, automotive and semiconductor sectors — conceived this initiative as part of their healthcare Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) commitment in India. **"This gathering isn't about technology showcases; it's about creating awareness and bringing diverse stakeholders to one table. While we do have diagnostic instruments, our focus today is building a movement of sensitivity and shared responsibility around the effective use of antibiotics."** remarked Dr. Gautam, affirming HORIBA's dedication to public health advocacy. This program was a CSR initiative by HORIBA India to promote awareness for preventive healthcare, contributing to the overall well-being of the society.

Further deepening the conversation was D**r. Ravi Gaur,** Chairman, Medical Advisory Committee, Oncquest Laboratories and Founder, DRG Path Labs, who also moderated the roundtable. Offering a human and clinical perspective, he stressed the silent, dangerous nature of AMR and the indispensable role of diagnostics. **"AMR is one of the biggest silent threats of our generation. It creeps in quietly, turning once-curable infections into untreatable diseases. We cannot wait for ICU admissions to act — decisions must be evidence-based, made much earlier, even at the pharmacy counter. Around 52% of antibiotics in India are sold over the counter. This is where point-of-care testing could make a monumental difference,"** he stated. Dr. Gaur called for faster diagnostic interventions, stronger clinician-lab partnerships, and clear, actionable outcomes from the gathering.

Delivering the government's national perspective, **Dr. Lata Kapoor,** Additional Director & Head, Centre for Bacterial Disease and Drug Resistance and AMR Containment, NCDC, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, addressed the seriousness of India's AMR crisis and the urgent need for coordinated action. She stressed that **"AMR is now a silent pandemic, one of the most serious public health challenges facing India and the world. The irrational use**